

A HOMECOMING WRITTEN IN BLACK

Kimi Antonelli produced a **remarkable** Monza masterclass, fighting back from 19th to win his home Italian Grand Prix and extend his championship lead.

Anish Pathiyil

anish.p@thehindu.co.in

There are very few moments in Formula One that can match the passion of the podium ceremony at the Italian Grand Prix, especially when the beloved Scarlet Red colour adorns the top step. Michael Schumacher, Rubens Barrichello, Fernando Alonso, and Charles Leclerc have all enjoyed the privilege of the Tifosi's undying adulation on track in the 21st century.

But this time, there was a key difference. The red was replaced by jet-black. The ferocious sound of 'Fratelli d'Italia' (Brothers of Italy — the national anthem) pierced through the skies regardless.

The circuit was stunned into silence two laps in, when Leclerc lit up his Ferrari's rear tyres and careered into the barriers at the end of Curva Alboreto. Fifty laps later, the crowd found its voice again. **Just two weeks after turning 20, Kimi Antonelli achieved something only four Italians have ever managed: winning their home Grand Prix at Monza. And to think that the Mercedes driver began the race from 19th on the grid!**

There have been enough superlatives written about the Bolognese driver this season. Leading the championship midway through your sophomore year in

From the depths of the grid to the top step: Kimi Antonelli's victory from 19th at Monza is the second-furthest-back starting position for a Grand Prix winner. GETTY IMAGES

the sport deserves all the headlines in itself. Ending a 60-year wait to see a hometown hero win the race at the 'Temple of Speed' — Ludovico Scarfiotti was the last to do it in 1966 — and the sheer dominance with which he completed it elevates it into a chapter in history. Standing on the pedestal, a teary-eyed and crimson-faced Antonelli knew it.

"Unbelievable, I'm so happy and I could never have imagined to be here today but we managed to pull it off," Antonelli said after the race, adding that it was "a dream coming true".

By the time Leclerc's crash forced a red flag and race restart, Antonelli had already scythed his way through to 12th place. The restart allowed him to get rid of the hard tyres and put on the faster mediums, which made his job easier. Within no time, 13 laps to be precise, he was breathing down the neck of teammate George Russell, who was leading the race.

The two championship protagonists traded blows, playing with their battery boosts to exchange the lead multiple times. Mercedes threatened to hinder the